

Survey Design and Analysis — Session 4 Workshop

Wording, Response Options, Order, and Sensitive Questions

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1. Finish the reading workshop

Your group is responsible for one reading lens: **Groves Ch. 7**, **Krosnick & Presser**, or **Pew's question-writing guidance**.

1. What is the central methodological claim?
2. What assumption about respondents or measurement is underneath it?
3. What survey-design decision follows from that claim?
4. What could go wrong if we ignore it?
5. What is one boundary condition, tradeoff, or challenge to the recommendation?

2. Schwarz lab: diagnose the mechanism

Group A — Comprehension

How often have you exercised regularly during the past year?

Group B — Retrieval

Compare: *How many times did you eat at a restaurant during the past seven days?* with the same question using *the past six months*.

Group C — Response scale

Create two different frequency scales for the same behavior and predict how each scale could alter reports.

Question	Notes
What is the respondent trying to infer or retrieve?	
What feature of the instrument changes that task?	
What error or heterogeneity could result?	
What redesign would help? What might it sacrifice?	

3. Trend decision: fix it or preserve it?

A client has asked the following question for 15 years:

How would you rate the state of your household finances today: excellent, good, only fair, or poor?

The client wants to add explicit language about paying bills and handling unexpected expenses because they believe respondents interpret “finances” inconsistently.

Recommendation: Keep / Replace / Run both / Other: _____

Why?

What evidence would you want before changing the trend?

4. Tourangeau–Yan sensitive-question lab

Your client wants an accurate measure of household financial strain using items on income, missed housing or utility payments, debt burden, public assistance, and inability to pay for necessities.

Item	Why sensitive?	Likely response problem / design response
Income		
Missed payments		
Debt burden		
Public assistance		
Necessities		

Module decisions

1. Where do you expect **item nonresponse** versus **misreporting**?
2. Would interviewer presence change the problem? Why?
3. Exact values or categories? Why?
4. What privacy cue, introduction, wording change, or response design would you use?
5. What information are you willing to sacrifice to reduce burden or threat?
6. How would you know whether the redesign improved measurement?

5. Integrated item audit

Use this before approving an item for fielding.

Audit question	Your answer
What construct / dimension is this intended to measure?	
What cognitive task must the respondent perform?	
What does the wording, response scale, and context communicate?	
Why might the respondent edit, withhold, or approximate the answer?	
What claim will the resulting variable actually support?	

You are handed a survey item that seems clear and grammatically clean. What are the **three most important questions** you would now ask before deciding that it is a good measure?

1.

2.

3.